Public Relations Review 48 (2022) 102202



Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Public Relations Review

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/pubrev





When transparent leadership communication motivates employee advocacy: Testing the mediator roles of employee attributions in CEO activism

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Transparent leadership communication
CEO activism
Genuine attribution
Self-serving attribution
Employee advocacy

ABSTRACT

This study examined employees' self-serving and genuine attributions of CEO activism as mediators, focusing on how they explain the process through which CEO's transparent leadership communication impacts employees' company advocacy and issue advocacy behaviors. With a survey of U.S. full-time employees, results showed that genuine attribution mediated the influence of transparent leadership communication on both advocacy variables. However, self-serving attribution was not identified as a significant mediator. Furthermore, though transparent leadership communication was not significantly associated with self-serving attribution, the latter was positively related to both issue advocacy intention and company advocacy intention. Highlighting the mediating roles of employee attributions, the findings of this study provide an advanced understanding of employee advocacy behaviors as impacted by transparent leadership communication in CEO activism.

1. Introduction

The phenomenon that Chief Executive Officers (CEOs) take a public stance on social, political, and environmental topics unrelated to their companies' bottom lines and without any obvious pretense of raising profits is termed CEO activism (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). It is worth noting that CEO activism activities are (a) enacted by the individual CEOs, (b) purposely in public, and (c) not directly impacting the company's core business and operational performance (Cewe, 2020; Chatterji & Toffel, 2019; Hambrick & Wowak, 2021). In their annual insights reports, Weber Shandwick has rated CEO activism as a prominent phenomenon for four consecutive years (Weber Shandwick & KRC Research, 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019). It is also projected to continue thriving in the future (Segal, 2020). According to the 2021 Edelman Trust Barometer global report, for-profit companies are perceived as more ethical and competent compared to nonprofit, government, and media, becoming the only trusted sector globally (Edelman, 2021). Therefore, it is not surprising that stakeholders expect corporate leaders or CEOs to address and solve social challenges and contribute to sociopolitical changes with the same effort they have spent on making profits (Edelman, 2021). Consequently, consumers are found to boycott or proactively purchase products based on whether they agree with a CEO's political stance (Edelman, 2020; Weber Shandwick & KRC Research, 2016, 2017). Internally, CEO activism also affects employees' cognitive and behavioral reactions. For example, employees' loyalty toward their company (Weber Shandwick & KRC Research, 2018), motivations at work (Burbano, 2020), turnover intention, employee activism, and employee nonaction (Brown et al., 2020) are revealed to associate with CEO activism. The magnitude and direction of such associations depend on whether their CEOs expressed sociopolitical stances in public and the stance alignment between CEOs and employees (Branicki et al., 2021).

Prior research work that investigated CEO activism covered a wide range of topics, including stance consistency, stakeholder-organization ideological fit, the morality of the advocated issue, peer group influence, ethical climate, CEO power in the organization, and more (e.g., Branicki et al. 2021; Brown et al., 2020; Burbano, 2020; Hambrick & Wowak, 2021). However, limited research has delved into communication strategies, especially leadership communication strategy, surrounding CEO activism. In practice, understanding how CEOs implement their communicative expression of a controversial sociopolitical issue in the public sphere is complex and essential (Arthur W. Page Society, 2007; Chatterji & Toffel, 2019). Public relations professionals are demanded to build entire practices around CEO activism (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). Notably, leadership communication literature suggests

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https://doi.org/10.1016/j.pubrev.2022.102202
Received 23 July 2021; Received in revised form 10 January 2022; Accepted 16 April 2022
Available online 26 April 2022
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that CEOs should remain transparent when communicating their opinions in public and thus be perceived as genuine (Yim, 2019). Hence, transparent leadership communication is chosen as the focal antecedent in this study depicting how CEOs convey their stances to various groups of stakeholders.

Furthermore, as employees learn about CEOs' communicated stances on sociopolitical issues, two questions arise: (1) how do they make attributions of their CEOs' activism initiatives; and (2) how do such attributions impact their behavioral intentions toward the corporation (i.e., company advocacy intention) and the focal issue (i.e., issue advocacy intention)? Drawn from the attribution theory, this study tests two types of attributions employees make in gauging and assessing the motives behind CEO activism: genuine attribution and self-serving attribution. Genuine attribution indicates a judgment that CEOs engage in activism out of their moral obligations in the community and the society (Cewe, 2020; Hambrick & Wowak, 2021; Chatterji & Toffel, 2018; Jahn et al., 2020). On the other hand, self-serving attribution describes a diagnosis that corporate interest and external reward drive CEOs' activism initiatives (Cewe, 2020; Hambrick & Wowak, 2021; Chatterji & Toffel, 2018; Jahn et al., 2020). The findings of this study indicated that transparent leadership communication can positively impact employees' behavioral intentions via the mediating role of genuine attribution. However, self-serving attribution was not a significant mediator.

Ultimately, this study has several contributions to public relations, leadership communication, and CEO activism literature. Theoretically speaking, we expanded the explanatory power of attribution theory to the CEO activism context and tested the different mediating roles of genuine attribution and self-serving attribution that employees make when exposed to CEO activism initiatives. Second, as an initial effort to scrutinize the impact of transparent leadership communication on employee advocacy behaviors, this study offered insights on leadership communication strategies in public relations practice surrounding CEO activism. Lastly, moving beyond the conventional investigation of corporate-focused outcome variables, this study also captured behavioral intentions regarding the focal sociopolitical issues (i.e., issue advocacy), which underscored the societal impact of CEO activism.

2. Literature review

2.1. CEO activism

CEO activism has become a new trend in U.S. society where corporate leaders publicly speak out their viewpoints on social, political, and/or environmental issues that are not directly related to the company's core business (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). It needs to be acknowledged that CEO activism shares common grounds with corporate activities that intend to foster social changes, such as corporate social responsibility (CSR), corporate political advocacy (CPA), and corporate social advocacy (CSA) (Ciszek & Logan, 2018; Lee & Tao, 2021). Furthermore, one similarity among CEO activism, CPA and CSA is that they all bear controversial nature and encompass various sociopolitical issues unrelated to the core business to foster social changes (Ciszek & Logan, 2018; Hong & Li, 2020; Lee & Tao, 2021). On the other hand, CEO activism also has distinctive features compared to CSR, CPA, and CSA. CEO activism is grounded in individual corporate leaders' behaviors, enacted by CEOs, and has a more explicit attachment to the CEOs themselves; whereas the latter three are organizational conducts where companies engage in particular social or political issues (Ciszek & Logan, 2018; Dodd & Supa, 2014; Hambrick & Wowak, 2021; Supa & Dodd, 2015). In other words, individual CEOs are the locus of action in CEO activism, whereas companies are the action agents in CSA, CPA, and CSR (Bedendo & Siming, 2021; Chatterji & Toffel, 2019).

From the perspectives of stakeholders' expectations, in CEO activism, internal and external stakeholders have their expectations toward CEOs as corporate or business leaders to exert impacts on society (Lee & Tao, 2021). In other words, stakeholders anticipate CEOs to act as agents and exert societal impacts with their social influences as individuals (Hambrick & Wowak, 2021). Results from the 2021 Edelman Trust Barometer support these increased expectations. It is reported that 43% of the globally surveyed stakeholders regard CEOs as societal leaders and expect them to talk about social issues in public. Therefore, CEOs ought to take the lead on change rather than wait for the government to impose changes (Edelman, 2021). In contrast, in CSA/CPA, the stakeholders' expectations are attributed to corporations, urging them to engage in public discussions of various controversial sociopolitical issues (Rim et al., 2020).

Additionally, CEO activism leveraged CEOs' individual social influence in planning and execution. As symbolic figureheads of companies, CEOs' personal characteristics, beliefs, morality, personalities, leadership styles, and communication styles all can influence CEO activism outcomes, such as promoting organizational reputation and facilitating significant social changes (Bedendo & Siming, 2021; Branicki et al., 2021; Ginzel et al., 2004). Reflected in communication tactics, CEO activism messages often come from a CEO's own communication action and public expression (e.g., CEO's personal social media channel, public statements, interviews) (Chatterji & Toffel, 2016, 2018). In contrast, CSR, CPA, or CSA messages are primarily transmitted via corporate communication channels (e.g., official website, corporate social media) (Lim & Young, 2021). Message strategies also differ correspondingly. That is, effective CEO activism communication messages are often more interpersonal and guided by leadership and interpersonal communication models and theories, such as transformational CEO leadership (Lee & Tao, 2021); while CPA and CSA messages are in accordance with corporate communication strategies and business decisions (Hong & Li, 2020; Lim & Young, 2021).

It needs to be noted that CEO activism, CSA, and CPA, though all encompassing stances-taking on controversial issues, may or may not co-occur within a company-led advocacy campaign. For instance, Apple CEO Tim Cook publicly displays his support to the LGBTQ+ community. He leverages his social influence as Apple CEO to be vocal on social media and join other celebrities to raise money for the community (Rollins, 2021; Wakefield, 2020). Meanwhile, Apple also takes a public stance supporting the LGBTQ+ community, the endeavors of which are considered as CSA. As a corporation, Apple has focused its CSA strategies on organizational initiatives, such as introducing Apple Watch Pride Edition and building long-term financial support for LGBTQ+ advocacy organizations (Apple, 2021). This case demonstrates that CEO activism and CSA/CPA can have a shared sociopolitical stance and co-occur. In a different example, CEO's stance-taking can happen without joint actions from CSA/CPA. When Texas lawmakers passed a restrictive abortion law in summer 2021, Shar Dubey, the CEO of Match Group, publicly took a stand against the law and created a fund to support her employees affected by the new law (i.e., CEO activism). She deliberately clarified that her actions and words are separated from Match Group's engagement into the issues (i.e., CPA), stating that "The company did not take a stand. I took a stand" (Gelles, 2021).

Nowadays, within an increasingly polarized society, CEOs are expected to bring social impacts through their words and deeds because their voices can be heard by both internal and external stakeholders, reaching a wide range of audiences (Edelman, 2021; Weber Shandwick & KRC Research, 2019). Given its unique characteristics discussed above, CEO activism can make stakeholders wonder about the reasons behind a CEO's stance taking on controversial issues, which sometimes leads to positive feedback and benefits organization's image, and, at other times, would cause charges of hypocrisy or even damage the reputation of a corporation and its corporate leader (Chatterji & Toffel, 2018). Employees are the most essential internal stakeholders of CEO activism, and previous scholars have studied and emphasized the importance of perceived morality in CEO activism in fostering positive attitudes among employees (Branicki et al., 2021; Lee & Tao, 2021). However, little research has investigated how employees interpret and perceive the motivations behind their leaders' activism initiatives.

Thereby, employees' interpretation and attribution of CEOs' motivation in activism is our study focus, and attribution theory is selected as the central theoretical framework.

2.2. Attribution theory and CEO activism

Attribution theory states that people make attributions or inferences of an event or behavior (Weiner, 1985). The attributions individuals make can be either intrinsic/dispositional or extrinsic/situational (Heider, 1944). In communication research, the application of attribution theory has illuminated how and why stakeholders assign particular motives to organizations' communication practice (e.g., CSR programs as in Ji et al., 2021; Rifon et al., 2004). In other words, the attribution process concerns how stakeholders make sense of the organization's intentionality behind its communication programs (Vlachos et al., 2017). It is argued that when learning about corporate initiatives, stakeholders can differentiate extrinsic vs. intrinsic motives (Calder & Staw, 1975; Pai et al., 2015), firm-serving vs. public-serving motives (Kim & Lee, 2012), and self-serving vs. genuine motives (Vlachos et al., 2017). For instance, stakeholders are more likely to consider corporate motives as extrinsic, firm-serving, or self-serving when they perceive companies are being driven by external rewards, such as receiving increased corporate reputation evaluation and improving profitability (Skarmeas & Leonidou, 2013; Jahn et al., 2020). On the other hand, when stakeholders regard companies' programs as fulfilling moral obligations and interest in serving society in the long term, they formulate a judgment that corporate motives are intrinsic, public-serving, or genuine (Jahn et al., 2020).

Following the above arguments, in the CEO activism context, this study contemplates that individuals can also form two distinct attributions when corporate leaders publicly express their sociopolitical stances. Mainly, when CEO activism is considered the fulfillment of CEOs' moral obligations and aims to foster social changes surrounding particular sociopolitical issues, genuine attribution is made by the employees. However, when employees perceive CEO activism activities as driven by achieving company interests, such as boosting reputation and avoiding potential criticism, they may classify such activities as self-serving (Cewe, 2020; Hambrick & Wowak, 2021; Toffel & Chatterji, 2018).

In CSR and CSA research, scholars suggested that genuine vs. self-serving attributions are not simply bipolar judgments of corporate motives. Rather they can coincide (Ellen et al., 2006; Kim & Lee, 2012; Story & Neves, 2015). Kim and Lee (2012) found that both public-serving and firm-serving intentionality attribution of a company's CSR program can enhance perceived trustworthiness of the company. In a study about employees' response toward CSR initiatives, both intrinsic and extrinsic attributions jointly impact employees' in-role job-related performance and out-role performance beyond traditional job descriptions (Story & Neves, 2015).

Although by the definition of CEO activism, CEOs' stance taking should not derive from the purpose of affecting the company's bottom line, it is possible that stakeholders may understand and perceive CEOs' motive to express sociopolitical stances in different ways. For instance, CEO activism can be considered as genuine service to the community and society (i.e., genuine attribution), as well as pragmatic means to achieving organizational objectives (e.g., employee or consumer retention) (i.e., self-serving attribution) (Branicki et al., 2021; Larcker et al., 2018). In fact, CEOs' value expression through activism activities is found to be aided (or suppressed) by stakeholders' expectations and corporate interests in general (Hambrick & Wowak, 2021). Larcker et al. (2018) analyzed 186 CEOs' public statements from S&P 500 companies addressing social and political issues. They concluded that CEOs clearly expressed their personal beliefs and moral obligations on social and political matters in some statements. However, some are ambiguous about their motives. In this regard, we aim to inspect how stakeholders, particularly employees, perceive their CEOs' activism behaviors and diagnose attributions of intentionality. Based on previous findings, the processes of both self-serving attribution and genuine attribution are investigated.

2.3. Antecedent of employees' attribution of CEO activism: transparent leadership communication

The phenomenon of CEO activism is situated in today's increasingly polarized society, where internal and external stakeholders are exposed to different voices on various social, political, and/or environmental issues. When the CEO of a business decides to take a public stance, one paramount communication strategy is to be open and transparent when communicating their opinion. Rawlins (2009) defined organizational transparency as a conscious and strategic attempt to make all legally releasable information available, both positive and negative, to enhance stakeholders' reasoning ability and hold organizations accountable for their actions, policies, and practice. From the internal stakeholders' perspective, transparency is also a crucial element of effective leadership communication (Men & Stacks, 2014; Rawlins, 2009). Effective leadership in promoting social change cannot function in its fullest capacity without communication. The adoption of transparent leader communication demonstrates a CEO's altruistic interest in maintaining or enhancing relationships with employees (Yue et al., 2019). The context of CEO activism campaigns should not be an exception.

Previous literature has outlined three dimensions of transparent communication: participation, accountability, and substantiality (e.g., Jiang & Luo, 2018; Rawlins, 2009). Among them, *participation* refers to engaging stakeholders in the decision-making process by inviting them to present feedback and delineate information obliged (Jiang & Luo, 2018; Rawlins, 2009; Yue et al., 2019). Notably, in the CEO activism context, CEOs should listen to what the employees articulate when expressing their own stance with participatory transparency. They ought to respond to employees' comments with comprehensive information. Consequently, employees shall have sufficient information to make informed decisions about how they would react to the CEO's activism initiatives. *Accountability* warrants that CEOs are accountable for their communication and behaviors (Jiang & Luo, 2018; Rawlins, 2009). In CEO activism communication, it underscores that the CEO is responsible for detailing both sides of a story and being open to criticism or opposition from employees as issues advocated in CEO activism can be controversial by nature (Yue et al., 2019). Lastly, *substantiality* highlights the importance of catering truthful, substantial, and valuable information for relevant stakeholder groups (Jiang & Luo, 2018; Rawlins, 2009). In CEO activism, communication with substantial transparency imports that the CEO should implement timely, reliable, complete, and relevant data and background information regarding the focal issue. Accordingly, merely claiming personal stances and subjective opinions are discouraged and should be avoided.

In prior research, transparency has been identified as an effective and ethical communication strategy in establishing organizational trust, credibility, and mutual understanding with employees in various contexts, such as employing CSR campaigns, facilitating organizational change, enhancing work-life balance, and managing crisis (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2011; Jiang & Men, 2017; Kim, 2018; Yue et al., 2019). For instance, when companies track and disclose records of their CSR program information, reveal both successes and failures of their CSR processes by honestly presenting facts, stakeholders are more likely to rate them as credible, genuine, and trustworthy (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2011; Kim & Ferguson, 2018; Saat & Selamat, 2014; Schlegelmilch & Pollach, 2005). Similarly, Du and colleagues (2010) also stated that reporting comprehensive CSR information is essential to eliminate stakeholder's skepticism of corporate intention in CSR efforts. Effective and transparent CSR communication is also found to be negatively associated with stakeholder's level of inclination to doubt about the company's altruism of its claimed socially responsible positions and actions (Du et al., 2010; Kim & Rim, 2019; Rim & Kim, 2016).

Synthesizing the above discussions, it is logical to assume that similar patterns can be observed in CEO activism. Although, as mentioned previously, in advocacy and social change campaigns, instrumental and pragmatic motives are sometimes accepted by stakeholders, they are regarded as less ethical and morally infused compared to genuine and society-serving motivations (Alcañiz et al., 2010; Jahn et al., 2020). Whereas, transparent leadership communication stems from the ethical and accountable aspects of building trustworthy and mutually beneficial ties with employees, which conceptually is incongruent with the self-serving motive that induces stakeholders to judge the honesty and legitimacy of the initiative (Alcañiz et al., 2010; Kim, 2018; Yue et al., 2019). It is revealed that communicating a company's CSR with intentional omission or exaggeration of its activities and outcomes can hinder the company's credibility resulting in stakeholders perceive its CSR program with high self-serving motives and low sincerity for serving society (Kim & Lee, 2012; Kim & Ferguson, 2018; Yoon et al., 2006). Thus, based on these lines of previous research findings, this study proposes that being exposed to transparent leadership communication will strengthen employees' genuine attribution of CEO activism initiatives and attenuate their self-serving attribution.

H1: Transparent leadership communication leads to employees' genuine attribution of CEO activism initiatives.

H2: Transparent leadership communication reduces employees' self-serving attribution of CEO activism initiatives.

2.4. Outcomes of employees' attribution on CEO activism: issue advocacy and company advocacy intentions

According to the attribution theory, people's inferences made to explain activities or events can impact their corresponding behaviors (Weiner, 1985). Generally speaking, when genuine attribution is made, people will feel compelled to respond positively as their needs for morality and fairness shall be met (Vlachos et al., 2017). However, self-serving motives signal instrumental reasons behind cooperative activities (e.g., making profits) and lead to skepticism as to why companies engage in activities that are not directly related to their businesses. Such a judgment can also threaten individuals' needs for morality and thus decrease their intention to react positively (Vlachos et al., 2017). In CSR and CSA literature, self-serving or extrinsic attribution has been found to lead to suspicion toward the corporations and thus negatively affect perceived corporate credibility and stakeholders' evaluation of the corporation and their CSR program (Jahn et al., 2020; Skarmeas & Leonidou, 2013; Yoon et al. 2006). On the other hand, genuine, intrinsic, or value-driven attribution was found to enhance corporate credibility (Jahn et al., 2020), purchase intention (Groza et al., 2011), and employee advocacy (Vlachos et al., 2017). Additionally, the impact of CSR on company advocacy is found to be more pronounced when strong intrinsic attribution and weak extrinsic attribution were made (Pai et al., 2015). Combining the aforementioned empirical findings, it is legitimate to argue that when employees make genuine attributions of CEO activism activities, positive outcomes shall be generated; however, if self-serving attributions are made, negative consequences are expected. It is worth noting that the stance consistency between CEOs and employees on the focal issue can also influence the outcomes of CEO activism. For example, a congruent stance was found to link with more positive consequences, such as increased employee activism participation and strengthened identification with employer organization (Brown et al., 2020; Hambrick & Wowak, 2021). However, since this study mainly sets out to understand the impact of employees' attributions of CEO activism, we choose to control stance consistency as a covariant in our proposed and tested model.

Previous studies on CEO activism and employees have investigated outcome variables such as job pursuit intention (Voegtlin et al., 2019), employer loyalty (Larcker et al., 2018), satisfaction (Yim, 2019), work retention (van Loon et al., 2016), turnover intention, employee activism and employee nonaction (Brown et al., 2020). Most studies emphasize the risks and opportunities brought to the corporations themselves when CEOs engage in activism initiatives (Cewe, 2020). However, the influence of CEO activism on social issues remains to be further investigated (Chatterji & Toffel, 2016; Edelman, 2020, 2021). Therefore, this study aims to unfold two aspects of employee responses to CEO activism, one being toward the employer organization and the other targeting the focal sociopolitical issue. In particular, employees' intention to participate in activities advocating for their supported issue stance (i.e., issue advocacy intention) and intention to advocate for their employer organization (i.e., company advocacy intention) are selected as the two outcomes of this study. Based upon the differences between genuine attribution and self-serving attribution discussed earlier, the following hypotheses are generated.

H3: Genuine attribution is positively related to (a) issue advocacy intention and (b) company advocacy intention.

H4: Self-serving attribution is negatively related to (a) issue advocacy intention and (b) company advocacy intention.

2.5. Attributions as mediators

Individuals' attributions of motivations behind corporate initiatives have been empirically supported as mechanisms explicating their responses to these corporate programs. Ginder et al., 2021 argued that intrinsic and extrinsic attributions can explain how consumers' purchase intention is impacted by their perceived congruence between internal CSR action and external CSR claim. To be specific, the type of congruence (e.g., uniform position, discrete position) was found to determine the strength of intrinsic and extrinsic attributions that consumers made; moreover, stronger intrinsic attribution and weaker extrinsic attribution would give rise to greater purchase intentions. Similarly, Kim and Choi (2018) empirically demonstrated how consumers' attribution of corporate altruism served as the underlying mechanism regarding the influence of CSR initiatives as a post-crisis response strategy on consumer responses. To elaborate, it was supported that altruism motives' attribution mediated the interaction between (a) pre-crisis and post-crisis CSR initiative congruence and (b) crisis issue and pre-crisis CSR initiative consistency, on attitude toward the corporation and purchase intention. Ellen et al. (2006) tested and confirmed that several motive attributions can mediate the relationship between company-cause fit and purchase intention. For instance, evidence showed that higher fit reduced consumers' suspicion and drove them to attribute value-driven motives, while lower fit might raise skepticism and led to more egoistic attribution. In turn, value-driven attribution had positive impacts on purchase intention, whereas egoistic attribution decreased purchase intention.

According to previous empirical evidence, it is reasonable to hypothesize that the two types of attribution (i.e., genuine attribution and self-serving attribution) can also explain the CEO activism communication process, elucidating how employees' attributional inferences based upon CEOs' activism communication would affect their subsequent behaviors toward the advocated issue itself (i.e., issue advocacy intention) and their employer organization (i.e., company advocacy intention). Particularly, it is suspected that the more transparent CEOs are in delivering their sociopolitical stances, the higher level of genuine attribution employees would make and thus leading to higher issue advocacy and company advocacy intentions. Additionally, with a higher level of transparency in CEO's communication of sociopolitical stances, it is expected that employees' self-serving attribution will be prohibited, which in turn would enhance issue advocacy and company advocacy intentions. Therefore, the following hypotheses are generated.

H5: Genuine attribution mediates the relationship between transparent leadership communication and issue advocacy intention.

H6: Genuine attribution mediates the relationship between transparent leadership communication and company advocacy intention.

H7: Self-serving attribution mediates the relationship between transparent leadership communication and issue advocacy intention.

H8: Self-serving attribution mediates the relationship between transparent leadership communication and company advocacy intention.

A conceptual model with all proposed hypotheses can be found in Fig. 1.

3. Methods

To test the proposed model and hypotheses, an online survey was created using Qualtrics and distributed to a panel of employees in the United States. Participants, to be able to proceed in the questionnaire, had to work full-time for a for-profit organization with its CEO actively advocating for a social, environmental, or political issue. A professional sampling service firm, Dynata, assisted the recruiting process, applying quota sampling strategy with comparable genders, age groups, and organization sizes across various income and education levels. Once participants were recruited and passed the screening questions, they were instructed to answer three thought-listing questions about their CEOs' advocated issue, stance on the issue, and communication channel. Then they were directed to provide their responses on a series of key variables and demographic questions.

A final sample of 600 participants was retained. Among them, 47.67% ($N = 286$) identified themselves as male, and 51.50% ($N = 309$) as female. More than half of the participants were Caucasian/White (61.17%, $N = 367$), followed by African American (15.33%, $N = 92$). Many of them had a bachelor's degree (40.83%, $N = 245$), followed by a master's degree (22.83%, $N = 137$). The majority of the participants were aged between 45 and 64 years old (48.50%, $N = 291$), followed by the age group between 25 and 44 (31.67%, $N = 190$). The majority of the participants worked for a company with a size of more than 1000 full-time employees (41.50%, $N = 249$). As for CEO gender, most employees had male CEOs (75.17%, $N = 451$). In terms of industry type, the largest proportion of the participants worked in Manufacturing (12.67%, $N = 76$).

More detailed demographic information can be found in Table 1.

All measurement scales were adopted from prior research and modified to fit into the context of this current study. Most key variables were measured with a seven-point Likert scale, with 1 representing "strongly disagree" and 7 representing "strongly agree." Among them, transparent leadership communication ($\alpha = 0.96$) was assessed with three dimensions ($\alpha = 0.88$ for participation, $\alpha = 0.93$ for substantiality, and $\alpha = 0.95$ for accountability) by 16 items adapted from Rawlins (2009) and Men and Bowen (2017). Example items are "When advocating for the issue, my CEO provides information in a timely fashion to employees like me" "When advocating for the issue, my CEO asks the opinions of people like me before making decisions." The measures of self-serving attribution ($\alpha = 0.92$) and genuine attribution ($\alpha = 0.88$) were adapted from Vlachos et al. (2017) and measured with three items, respectively. One example measurement for genuine attribution is "My CEO advocates for the issue responsibly because he/she feels morally obligated to help," while an example of self-serving attribution is "My CEO hopes to increase the company's profits by advocating for this issue."

Company advocacy intention ($\alpha = 0.91$) was measured with eight items and adapted from Tsai and Men (2016) and Thelen (2019). For instance, participants were asked to rate their degree of agreement with "I speak favorably about my company in public." The measure of issue advocacy intention ($\alpha = 0.91$) included four items adapted from Moskalenko and McCauley (2009). An example item is "I would join in a public rally, protest, or demonstration in support of an organization/group that advocates this issue." As one of the control variables, stance consistency with the CEO was measured by asking respondents to rate their degree of agreement with the statement, "I share the same stance as my CEO on THIS issue." Issue involvement ($\alpha = 0.95$) was measured with 10 items seven-point semantic scale adapted from Bae (2008), with example bipolar pairs being "important-important" and "boring-interesting."

4. Results

4.1. Confirmatory factor analysis

Prior to hypothesis testing, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was performed with SPSS Amos 25 to test the measurements. Among all the focal variables, transparent leadership communication was regarded as a second-order factor with its three underlying first-order dimensions: participation, substantiality, and accountability. Self-serving attribution, genuine attribution, company advocacy intention, and issue advocacy intention were treated as latent variables. Following criteria from Hu and Bentler (1999), confirmatory factor analysis revealed the measurement model achieved good data-model fit, $\chi 2(171) = 459.17$, $p < .001$, RMSEA = 0.05 (90% confidence interval:0.047, 0.059), SRMR = 0.04, CFI = 0.97, TLI = 0.96. Results showed that all indicators loaded significantly and positively on the corresponding latent variable ($p < .05$), and the standardized factor loadings ranged from .62 to.93[1]. Additionally, the average variance extracted (AVE) and the square root of AVE were calculated to further evaluate the construct validity for each measure. Results showed that the AVE value ranged from 0.57 to 0.79, surpassing the recommended value of AVE at 0.5 (Hair et al., 2010). The square root AVE value for each construct was also found to be greater than the corresponding correlation values. Therefore, these results indicate adequate convergent and discriminant validity for each construct.

4.2. Structural equation modeling

In the structural equation modeling process, a preliminary analysis was conducted to examine and identify potential confounding variables. Specifically, the potential effects of respondents' demographic factors (i.e., age, gender, education level, ethnicity), issue related variables (i.e., political stance, issue stance consistency, issue involvement), as well as company and CEO related variables (i.e., company size, industry type, CEO gender) on the focal variables of the study were tested. Results showed that only issue involvement and stance consistency with the CEO were significantly associated with the endogenous variables. Therefore, they were both entered as covariates in the follow-up structural equation modeling analysis.

Following Kline (1998), survey data were checked before conducting data analysis to assess (1) the linearity of the proposed relationships with curve estimation tests, (2) obvious outliers with Cook's distance tests, (3) multivariate normality with normality probability (Q-Q) plot, and (4) multicollinearity with tolerance and variance inflation factors (VIF). The hypothesized model demonstrated good model fit: $\chi 2$ (209) = 591.83, $p < .001$, RMSEA = 0.06 (90% confidence interval:0.050,0.061), SRMR = 0.05, TLI = 0.96, CFI = 0.96.

A summary of the mean, standard deviation, reliability coefficient and correlation among the key variables in this study can be found in Table 2.

4.3. Hypothesis testing

Direct effects. Hypothesis 1 and 2 hypothesized that transparent

[1] Factor loadings from transparent leadership communication to its subdimensions of participation, substantiality, and accountability were.88,.93,.79, respectively. Loadings from self-serving attribution to its indicators were.93,.83,.90, respectively. Loadings from genuine attribution to its indicators were.85,.85,.84 respectively. Loadings from company advocacy intention to its indicators were.81,.81,.83,.74,.62,.71,.71,.79 respectively. Loadings from issue advocacy intention to its indicators were.80,.88,.85,.86 respectively.

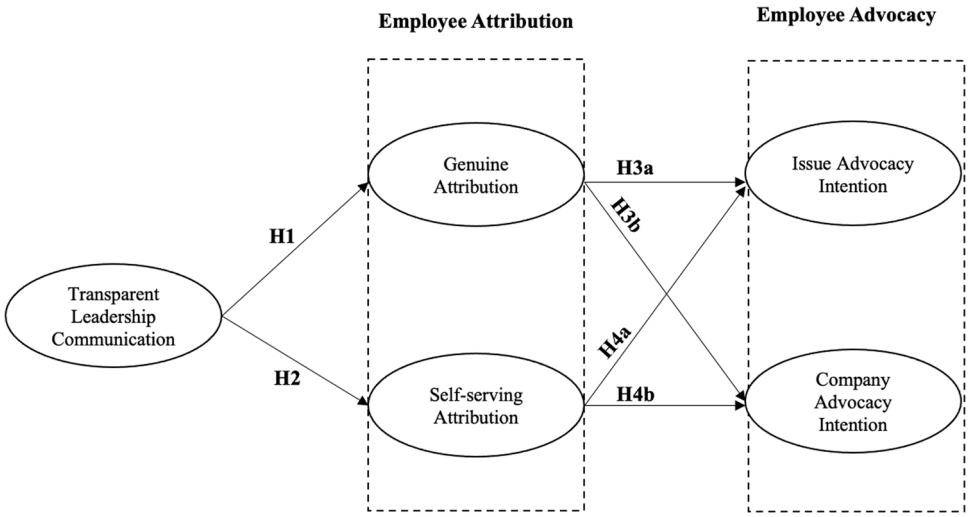


Fig. 1. The proposed conceptual model, Note. Mediation processes are H5–8.

leadership communication is positively related to employees' genuine attribution and negatively related to employees' self-serving attribution of CEO activism initiatives. Results indicated that the direct link between transparent leadership communication and genuine attribution was significant and positive ($\beta = 0.82$, $p < .001$); however, transparent leadership communication and self-serving attribution were not significantly associated, $p = .32$. Therefore, **hypothesis 1 was supported, but hypothesis 2 was not supported**. Additionally, **supporting hypothesis 3,** genuine attribution was found positively related to (a) issue advocacy intention ($\beta = 0.43$, $p < .001$) and (b) company advocacy intention ($\beta = 0.52$, $p < .001$). Opposite to what's hypothesized, self-serving attribution was found to significantly but positively relate to (a) issue advocacy intention ($\beta = 0.08$, $p = .004$), and (b) company advocacy intention ($\beta = 0.04$, p = .03). Therefore, **hypothesis 4 was partially supported.**

Indirect (mediation) effects. A formal test of indirect effects using a bootstrap procedure was conducted to test hypotheses 5–8 (Gaskin et al., 2020). Results showed that the indirect effect from transparent leadership communication to issue advocacy intention through genuine attribution was significant, $\beta = 0.35$, $p = .001$ (95% CI:.22 −0.49). Therefore, genuine attribution mediated the effect of transparent leadership communication on issue advocacy intention, **supporting hypothesis 5**. Additionally, a significant indirect path was found in the path from transparent leadership communication to company advocacy intention through genuine attribution, $\beta = 0.42$, $p = .001$ (95% CI:.33 −0.53), **supporting hypothesis 6.** In other words, genuine attribution was found to also mediate the impact of transparent leadership communication on company advocacy intention.

However, the indirect effect in the path from transparent leadership communication to issue advocacy intention through self-serving attribution was not found significant, $p = .25$, **failing to support hypothesis 7.** self-serving attribution was not found to significantly mediate the impact of transparent leadership communication on company advocacy intention, $p = .22$, thus **hypothesis 8 was not supported.**

A visualization of the supported model can be found in Fig. 2.

5. Discussions

This study investigated how employees make attributions of CEO activism when transparent leadership communication strategy is utilized by the CEOs and how employees' advocacy behaviors are influenced in this process. Applying the attribution theory to the CEO activism context and integrating perspectives from leadership communication and employee advocacy behaviors, this study contributes to public relations, leadership communication, and CEO activism literature by proposing and testing a mediation model. In the model, transparent leadership communication was found to positively influence employees' genuine attribution, but not self-serving attribution. Findings also showed that genuine attribution of CEO activism can explain the underlying process from transparent leadership communication to employee advocacy behaviors (i.e., company advocacy intention and issue advocacy intention). Additionally, though self-serving attribution was not identified as a significant mediator, it was found to positively predict employees' advocacy behaviors oriented to the advocated issue and their employers. Further discussions of these findings and implications to theory and practice are provided below.

5.1. The role of transparent leadership communication in CEO activism

A positive direct association between transparent leadership communication and employees' genuine attribution of CEO activism was supported in this study. Previous public relations scholars have acknowledged that effective communication strategy is an essential but underdeveloped concept in CEO activism literature (Ji et al., 2021; Lee & Tao, 2021). This study provided empirical evidence on the importance of transparent communication in successful CEO activism implementation from leadership and internal communication perspective. The concept of transparency has been closely tied to trust and credibility, as seen in various contexts. For instance, in internal communication research, empirical studies revealed that transparent internal communication is fundamental in fostering employee trust, boosting corporate reputation, and building and nurturing employee-organization relationships (Men & Stacks, 2014; Rawlins, 2009). More specifically, in corporate social responsibility studies, transparent communication is regarded as a constructive pillar of effective communication, and being informative about corporate activists was found to have a significant effect on public responses (Du et al., 2010; Kim, 2019; Kim & Rim, 2019). This study has further reinforced the notion that as CEOs increase their communication transparency, they will become more trusted by their employees regardless of stance consistency with the CEOs on the controversial issue (Rawlins, 2009). Specifically, open, honest, and ethical communication can narrow the information gaps between employees and the leadership, acknowledge the CEO's extrinsic and community-oriented motives and legitimacy of partaking in social advocacy. Upon sensing the CEO's sincere interest in looping them in the activism plan and contributing to social change, employees will be more likely to trust their genuine intention, morality, and capability in implementing the activism campaign. However, our results did not

Table 1
Participant profile (N = 600).

Sample characteristics	Frequency	Percent (%)
Gender		
Male	286	47.67
Female	309	51.50
Non-binary/third gender	1	.17
Prefer to self-describe	2	.33
I prefer not to say	2	.33
Ethnicity		
African American/Black	92	15.33
Asian/Pacific Islander	75	12.50
Caucasian/White	367	61.17
Latino/Hispanic	35	5.83
Native American	8	1.33
Other	17	2.83
Prefer not to say	6	1.00
Education		
No college (secondary education or below)	27	4.50
Vocational level (including diploma, higher diploma, and associate degree)	44	7.33
Some college	116	19.33
A bachelor's degree	245	40.83
A master's degree	137	22.83
A doctoral degree	29	4.83
Prefer not to say	2	.33
Age		
18–24	34	5.67
25–44	190	31.67
45–64	291	48.50
65 or above	85	14.17
Company Size		
under 40	111	18.50
40–99	51	8.50
100–249	75	12.50
250–499	38	6.33
500–999	76	12.67
above 1000	249	41.50
CEO Gender		
Male	451	75.17
Female	140	23.33
Non-binary/third gender	2	.33
I prefer not to say	7	1.16
Industry Type		
Agriculture, Forestry, Fishing and Hunting	7	1.17
Mining, Quarrying, and Oil and Gas Extraction	4	.67
Utilities	16	2.67
Construction	24	4.00
Manufacturing	76	12.67
Wholesale Trade	12	2.00
Retail Trade	64	10.67
Transportation and Warehousing	24	4.00
Information	21	3.50
Finance and Insurance	53	8.83
Real Estate and Rental and Leasing	16	2.67
Professional, Scientific, and Technical Services	71	11.83
Management of Companies and Enterprises	5	.83
Administrative and Support and Waste Management and Remediation Services	3	.50
Educational Services	33	5.50
Health Care and Social Assistance	62	10.33
Arts, Entertainment, and Recreation	17	2.83
Accommodation and Food Services	16	2.67
Public Administration	4	.67
Other	72	12.00

support the negative path between transparent leadership communication and self-serving attribution. Therefore, self-serving attribution was also not found to be a mediator between transparent communication and employee advocacy behaviors. We suspect that the conceptual incongruity between transparent leadership and self-serving motive, with the former being sincere and virtuous and the latter being pragmatic and egocentric, may have caused the insignificant links (Alcañiz et al., 2010; Jahn et al., 2020). In this circumstance, it is likely that participant employees did not employ transparent leadership communication as a cognitive cue to make inferences of the self-serving motive behind CEO activism.

5.2. Genuine vs. self-serving attribution

This study explored how employees make self-serving and genuine attributions when exposed to CEO's transparent leadership communication in activism initiatives and how these attributions impact their subsequent behaviors in relation to the employer company and the focal sociopolitical issue. Only genuine attribution was identified as a significant mediator connecting transparent leadership communication with both issue advocacy intention and company advocacy intention. These findings illuminated that the adoption of transparency strategy in communicating CEO activism messages can motivate employees to advocate for the focal issue and the employer company only when they think their CEOs fulfill moral obligations and serve the community or society (Jahn et al., 2020). In other words, as CEOs engage employees in the decision-making process of activism programs (i.e., participation), hold themselves accountable in issue- and stance-related message delivery (i.e., accountability), and emphasize the importance of valuable and substantial information provided to employees (i.e., substantiality), they prompt their employees to think about the moral values of their public stance-taking behavior and thus also take actions surrounding both the advocated issue and the employer company (Jiang & Luo, 2018; Rawlins, 2009; Yue et al., 2019).

An intriguing finding of this study is that though self-serving attribution was not a significant mediator, it was found to positively associate with both issue advocacy intention and company advocacy intention. Contrary to the predicted negative associations, our empirical findings demonstrated that even when employees perceive CEO activism initiative as motivated by corporate interest, they would still be inclined to champion their employer company and become involved in the advocated issue. One possible explanation is that as internal stakeholders, employees depend on the employer company's profitability to secure their jobs and have shared interests with their employer. Thus, they are very likely to recognize and accept that the purpose of their CEOs' involvement in public issue discussions is to improve organizational reputation and increase revenues. Consequently, as part of the organizations, employees can also be inspired and prompted to advocate for their employer company and for the discussed sociopolitical issue in their CEO's activism initiatives. Current findings indicate that it is not necessary to hide CEOs' self-serving motivations, especially among employees. Instead, both companies and CEOs can benefit from communicating some self-serving intentionality by prompting employees to speak up for the employer company and bolster the company's advocacy agenda. It is worth noting that genuine attribution was found to have stronger influences ($\beta = 0.43$ on issue advocacy intention and $\beta = 0.52$ on company advocacy intention) than self-serving attribution ($\beta = 0.08$ on issue advocacy intention and $\beta = 0.04$ on company advocacy intention). This finding further demonstrated that when CEO activism is perceived as morality-driven and intended to serve society, this interpretation of motivation would better align with employees' needs for morality to engage in advocacy behaviors.

Furthermore, our study findings confirmed the coexistence relationship between genuine and self-serving attributions in CEO activism context. Genuine attribution does not preclude self-serving attribution, and both are likely to produce positive outcomes (Kim & Lee, 2012; Story & Neves, 2015). In the typology developed by Branicki et al. (2021), CEO activism can be categorized based upon two dimensions of the issue domain within which activism occurs–the level of corporate instrumental self-interest related to the issue and the moral intensity of the issue in broader society. Our investigation of self-serving attribution has highlighted the instrumental aspect of CEO activism, while our examination of genuine attribution spotlighted its moral aspect.

Table 2
Means, standard deviations, and correlations among variables.

	Cronbach's alpha	M (SD)	1	2	3	4	5
1. Transparent leadership communication	.96	5.54 (1.14)	–				
2. Genuine attribution	.88	5.93 (1.13)	.690 * *	–			
3. Self-serving attribution	.92	4.25 (1.81)	.001	-0.082 *	–		
4. Issue advocacy intention	.91	5.01(1.47)	.618 * *	.514 * *	.056	–	
5. Company advocacy intention	.91	5.62 (1.07)	.626 * *	.595 * *	.029	.608 * *	–

Note: * ** $p < .001$, * * $p < .01$, * $p < .05$

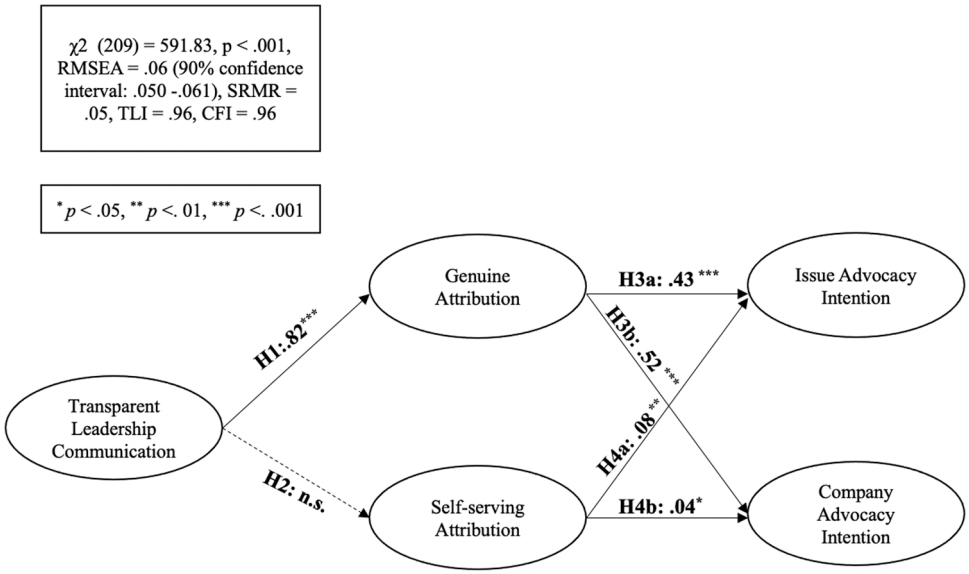


Fig. 2. Results of supported model. Note. Mediation processes H5:.35**; H6:.42**; H7: n.s.; H8: n.s.

5.3. Theoretical implications

Theoretically speaking, this study has several contributions. First, beyond traditional corporate initiatives such as CSR programs, this study adopts attribution theory as a mechanism to uncover employees' experience when they learn about their corporate leaders' sociopolitical opinions in CEO activism activities. In particular, genuine attribution is conceptualized and operationalized as inferences of CEO activism initiatives driven by moral obligation fulfillment, while self-serving attribution manifests employees' speculations of CEO activism programs with corporate purposes (e.g., enhancing reputation and making profits). Besides their conceptual differences, this study further confirmed the distinctiveness between genuine attribution and self-serving attribution related to transparent leadership communication. Findings of this study also illustrated that in the CEO activism context, both types of attributions can lead to positive advocacy behaviors from employees, supporting previous empirical evidence that self-serving attribution does not necessarily lead to adverse outcomes and two attributions can coexist (Ellen et al., 2006; Groza et al., 2011; Kim & Lee, 2012; Story & Neves, 2015).

This study also contributes to employee advocacy literature by assessing two different advocacy behaviors. Company advocacy behavior aims to bring positive outcomes to the employer company. Employees who engage in company advocacy will likely speak favorably about their employer company and take actions to help build their company's image and branding (Tsai & Men, 2016; Thelen, 2019). Examination of company advocacy behavior is in line with prior research efforts that centered on corporate-oriented outcomes (e.g., Brown et al., 2020; Larcker et al., 2018; van Loon et al., 2016). Furthermore, to answer the call for more research regarding the impact of CEO activism on public opinion and social issues (Chatterji & Toffel, 2016; Edelman, 2020, 2021), we also incorporated issue advocacy behavior as another dimension of employee advocacy, focusing on employees' activities and actions taken surrounding the sociopolitical issue advocated by their CEOs. Employees involved with issue advocacy are likely to join a relevant organization, volunteer, participate in protests and demonstrations, and so on (Moskalenko & McCauley, 2009). Our results contributed to the growing literature that takes a society-centric approach and highlighted positive social impacts brought by corporate leaders (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016).

Third, the findings of this study linked transparent leadership communication with employee advocacy behaviors and highlighted the significance of transparency in CEOs' communication with their internal stakeholders, employees. Though transparent leadership communication has been long supported as effectively predicting positive organizational outcomes in public relations and strategic communication fields (Coombs & Holladay, 2011; Saat & Selamat, 2014), this study acts as one of the initial efforts to reveal the underlying attribution processes employees experience as a response to this communication strategy and how different inferences that are made would motivate employee advocacy behaviors differently.

Last but not least, by linking transparent leadership communication strategy with genuine attribution and employee advocacy, this study showed that individual CEOs' effective communication behaviors in activism initiatives can eventually motivate employees to speak up for the company and advocate for the focal sociopolitical issue. Our findings substantiated individual CEOs' leadership communication impact. In the current context, leadership communication not only wins employees' support within an organization, but also mobilizes employees to advance society and community development (Edelman, 2021; Weber Shandwick & KRC Research, 2019). Such results contributed to illuminating the distinctiveness of CEO activism from other similar initiatives

promoting social change, such as CSR, CSA, and CPA, which is the social influence of CEOs (Ciszek & Logan, 2018; Dodd & Supa, 2014; Supa & Dodd, 2015). Therefore, our study provides more concrete contextual ground for future investigation of CEO activism.

5.4. Practical implications

Findings from this study also provide pragmatic implications for CEOs and public relations professionals guiding their strategic communication when planning and implementing CEO advocacy campaigns. First and foremost, CEOs ought to recognize that in today's society and business world, their responsibilities are beyond leading teams to impact company-oriented performance. They are also opinion leaders who have the capacity to mobilize organizational and individual resources in creating societally beneficial values. More influential roles come with more responsibilities; therefore, CEOs need to recognize the significance of effective communication in practicing activism and convey a balanced, motivating, and relatable story in issue advocacy, which can ultimately unify and guide employees to support positive social movements. As the results suggested, once motivated by their CEOs' activism communication, employees showed a substantial tendency to join an advocacy organization, make donations, volunteer, and attend demonstrations. They were also eager to show more support to the company both verbally and behaviorally. Most importantly, this study makes a compelling case for company leaders and public relations practitioners to keep reminding their employees that their CEO genuinely cares about the issue being advocated and the interest groups who are affected by the given pressing sociopolitical problems. As the findings demonstrated, when employees consider CEO's motivation as genuine and moral via transparent leadership communication, they tend to express higher likeability of partaking in similar advocacy initiatives. In designing the CEO's messages to employees, public relations practitioners should update the employees on the CEO activism impact by reporting actual deliverables using tangible matrices or beneficiary testimony regularly (Du et al., 2010). Data-infused and story-based sustainability reports can also be employed and distributed via internal channels to communicate about ongoing activism programs to increase leadership communication's transparency and accountability among employees. The reports should serve to minimize employee skepticism and the intention of categorizing CEO activism as self-serving. Therefore, the goals and objectives of CEO activism programs should be well-articulated. Employees also need to be well-informed about such programs' long-term and short-term implications to the issue being advocated. Altogether, transparent messages from leaders can help to highlight CEO's genuine concerns about the issue they advocate, emphasize CEO's shared moral responsibility to solve the program, and their eagerness to help and give back to the community and the society.

5.5. Limitation and future research

Admittedly, this study has its own limitations, which shed light on future research directions. First, employees' self-reported data was used to measure transparent leadership communication and behavioral intentions. The shortcoming of such a method is that the actual communication behavior of the CEO and employees' company advocacy and issue advocacy behaviors were not assessed objectively. Therefore, future studies should consider conducting content analysis to profile CEOs' communication strategies or using ethnographic studies to record employees' actual advocacy behaviors. Second, this study did not address the possibility that CEOs' personal ideologies may conflict with organizations' mission and values. Future studies (e.g., experiments) should be conducted to examine how the consistency of values between CEOs and companies can influence employees' responses to CEO activism. Third, only one attribute of leadership communication (i.e., transparent leadership communication) was examined in this study. More empirical research is needed to investigate the predicting effects of other leadership communication strategies (e.g., authentic leadership and transformational leadership). Lastly, we controlled stance consistency in our study to focus primarily on employees' attribution process; however, future field experimental studies can be conducted to explore the relationship between stance consistency and attribution types in CEO activism. For example, how would employees respond when they disagree with their CEO's stance but perceive the CEO activism activities as genuine?

Declaration of Competing Interest

The author(s) declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Acknowledgements

The authors want to thank the Robertson School of Media and Culture at Virginia Commonwealth University for funding this research.

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